

VOCABULARY BUILDER

Why Intelligent Children Often Struggle in Traditional Education – Key Words

The words and phrases below appear in the article *Why Intelligent Children Often Struggle in Traditional Education*. Study the table carefully — these are core Level B terms from education, psychology, and social policy that appear regularly in academic and professional contexts. Then complete the gap-fill exercise in Part 2.

PART 1 – VOCABULARY TABLE

WORD / PHRASE	DEFINITION	EXAMPLE SENTENCE
discontented	feeling unhappy or dissatisfied with one's situation, circumstances, or surroundings	<i>Many highly capable students become discontented with school not because they lack ability, but because the curriculum fails to challenge them.</i>
provincial	relating to a region outside the main cultural or intellectual centres; sometimes used to suggest limited horizons or lack of exposure	<i>Growing up in a provincial town with no access to libraries or mentors, she nonetheless developed a remarkable appetite for learning.</i>
subsidy	a sum of money granted by a government or institution to support an activity, individual, or organisation that could not otherwise sustain itself	<i>Without a government subsidy, many students from low-income backgrounds would be unable to complete university education.</i>
solidify	to make something stronger, more stable, or more firmly established	<i>Early mentorship can help talented children solidify their academic confidence before it is undermined by competitive environments.</i>
pseudonym	a fictitious name used by a writer or other public figure instead of their real name	<i>Several nineteenth-century female novelists published under a pseudonym to avoid the prejudice directed at women writers of the time.</i>
disdain	the feeling that someone or something is beneath one's dignity and unworthy of respect; contempt	<i>Her open disdain for rote learning made her unpopular with teachers, even though her intellectual curiosity was exceptional.</i>
unsophisticated	lacking refinement, complexity, or depth; simple in a way that suggests limited knowledge or experience	<i>Bright students often disengage when teaching methods feel unsophisticated — when they sense they are being talked down to.</i>
acquisition	the process of gaining or learning something, particularly a skill or body of knowledge	<i>Cognitive scientists now argue that language acquisition is most effective when learners are actively engaged rather than passively memorising rules.</i>
retention	the ability to keep information in memory over time; the rate at which learned material is remembered	<i>Active participation in storytelling and discussion dramatically improves long-term retention compared with traditional written exercises.</i>
sympathetic	showing understanding, kindness, and support towards someone's feelings or difficulties	<i>A sympathetic teacher can transform the experience of a struggling student — not by lowering standards, but by making the student feel seen.</i>
bankruptcy	the legal state of being unable to repay debts; financial ruin	<i>Several distinguished writers faced bankruptcy in mid-career, their literary reputations temporarily overshadowed by financial crisis.</i>
consolidate	to bring together separate things into a single, stronger, or more coherent whole; to strengthen what already exists	<i>His friends worked to consolidate his unpublished manuscripts into a single archive, ensuring the work would not be lost.</i>
sanatorium	a medical facility for the long-term treatment of chronic illness, historically associated with tuberculosis	<i>Despite being confined to a sanatorium for over a year, the writer continued to produce the essays that would later define his legacy.</i>

WORD / PHRASE	DEFINITION	EXAMPLE SENTENCE
foundational	forming an essential base or starting point; of fundamental importance to the development of something larger	<i>The collection of essays written during his illness is now considered foundational to modern theories of child-centred education.</i>
resilience	the capacity to recover from setbacks, adapt to difficult circumstances, and continue progressing	<i>Resilience in the face of early academic failure is one of the strongest predictors of long-term intellectual achievement.</i>
standardised	made uniform or consistent according to a fixed set of rules or criteria, applied equally to all	<i>Critics of standardised testing argue that it systematically disadvantages children whose intelligence does not fit neatly into measurable categories.</i>
self-directed	guided by one's own goals, interests, and judgement rather than by external instruction or authority	<i>Self-directed study allows students to pursue areas of genuine curiosity, which research suggests produces deeper and more durable learning.</i>
innovator	a person who introduces new ideas, methods, or approaches that change an existing field or practice	<i>Many of history's greatest innovators were considered difficult or undisciplined students — their resistance to convention was later understood as intellectual independence.</i>

PART 2 – GAP-FILL EXERCISE

Complete the sentences using the correct word or phrase from the word bank below. You may need to change the form of the word. Most sentences require more than one answer.

WORD BANK

discontented	provincial	subsidy	solidify
pseudonym	disdain	unsophisticated	acquisition
retention	sympathetic	bankruptcy	consolidate
sanatorium	foundational	resilience	standardised
self-directed	innovator		

1. Students who grow up in _____ communities far from major cities may develop sharp analytical minds, yet without financial _____ or institutional support, many fail to _____ their academic potential.
2. Several of the writers studied published their earliest work under a _____, fearing that their real identity would invite professional prejudice before they had established a reputation.
3. Her teachers described her as _____ and intellectually restless — someone whose barely concealed _____ for conventional teaching methods made her a disruptive presence in the classroom, despite being clearly gifted.
4. Research into language _____ increasingly challenges the traditional emphasis on passive memorisation, suggesting instead that active conversation and collaborative reading improve long-term _____.
5. A _____ mentor can be transformative for a child from a financially restricted background — not by removing challenges, but by providing the emotional stability needed to face them.
6. The distinction between intelligence and achievement is rarely a question of ability. More often it concerns _____ — the capacity to recover from setback and continue when circumstances become difficult.
7. After a period of financial failure that left him on the verge of _____, friends stepped in to _____ his scattered manuscripts into a single collection, which was eventually published to critical acclaim.
8. Admitted to a _____ following his diagnosis with tuberculosis, the writer continued working on essays that would later be recognised as _____ texts in the history of educational reform.
9. _____ assessment models have long been criticised for rewarding speed and obedience over creativity — producing students who perform well on paper but feel _____ with learning itself.
10. The shift towards _____ study models reflects a growing recognition that children whose talents are invisible under conventional assessment methods may flourish when given the freedom to direct their own learning.
11. Many historical _____ were described by their teachers as undisciplined or _____ students — individuals whose resistance to unsophisticated methods was later reinterpreted as intellectual independence.
12. The _____ of his unpublished journals decades after his death revealed a man deeply committed to educational reform — a commitment that his public image as a _____ figure had long obscured.

Write your answers here:

1. _____	2. _____	3. _____
4. _____	5. _____	6. _____
7. _____	8. _____	9. _____
10. _____	11. _____	12. _____

